

Scanning the iris in exchange for cryptocurrency. Spain blocks Worldcoin, and rightly so
Intervention by Guido Scorza, member of the Italian Data Protection Authority
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The Spanish Data Protection Authority has ordered Tools for Humanity Corporation, the company managing Worldcoin, to halt operations for three months in Spain, a country where the service already counts hundreds of thousands of users. This is an important step regarding an initiative that has raised various concerns around the world from the very beginning.

The initiative, born from the ingenuity of Sam Altman, founder of the well-known OpenAI, the company that produces and provides the ChatGPT service, which is not yet available in Italy, is essentially based on an exchange: users allow their irises and other facial features to be scanned, permitting the company to extract an extraordinary amount of biometric data, and in return, the company provides them with a sort of 'digital IOU' in cryptocurrency. Simplifying a dynamic that is, of course, more complex than this, essentially, Tools for Humanity pays, albeit in cryptocurrency, for some of the most sensitive data we possess.

The declared goal of the initiative is to create a sort of global digital passport that allows users of any service requiring identification to be identified with reasonable certainty. However, this goal has, from the outset, appeared to Altman and his companions to be impossible to achieve without finding a way to convince billions of people worldwide to allow their biometric data to be expropriated and handed over to a private company. Hence the 'flash of genius': to financially incentivize users to stand in front of Tools for Humanity's scanners and allow their irises to be read.

The rest is now history or, perhaps, better said, was on its way to becoming history with millions of users who, already during the launch phase of the service, had accepted the exchange. Then, yesterday, the halt from the Spanish Authority. A 'game' too dangerous for the Madrid Authority and, above all, a system that does not seem compatible with European regulations on personal data protection. Many concerns underlie the urgent measure: little transparency towards users who would not be placed in a position to truly understand the meaning of the exchange, the risk that even the biometric data of children and adolescents could end up in the company's scanners, and the apparent impossibility for individuals to reconsider and request their personal data back.

Doubts that are hard not to share. And doubts to which it may be worth adding one that will likely emerge in the coming months during the proceedings that will now inexorably involve the personal data protection authorities across Europe: is it really sustainable, in the legal dimension first and democratic later, an operation in which such precious data as biometric data, capable, in essence, of representing a person in the digital dimension and beyond, are exchanged for money or, in any case, other economic utility? Because, inevitably, if the answer is yes, one opens up to the risk that the economically less fortunate population of the world rushes to hand over their biometric data into the hands of the company founded by Altman, and that those who are 'unfortunately many' and lack sufficient education on the value of personal data and, more generally, rights do the same.

And that this is not a catastrophic scenario but merely realism is perhaps suggested by the fact that in countries like Chile, Uganda, or Kenya, Worldcoin has had, from the very beginning, particular success, a success certainly greater than that recorded in many other countries with better widespread economic conditions. We are only at the beginning of a story from which, probably, much depends—regardless of the fate of Altman's specific initiative—on the society in which we will find ourselves living and the very idea of the universality of fundamental rights.